CHAPTER 55

BACK ON THE BENCH

I am back on the bench. A raging hangover. An empty cricket field in front of me, the voice of a faceless man asking if I miss it that much already. As he leaves, I sit up slowly, the field and the pavilion coming into view – out of blurriness and back into focus. It is so still. Everything is so quiet. I feel like I have been running for a lifetime, all those collated incidents, all that drama and hurt and joy, all that noise and all those questions, to end up at the same spot. My whole universe has been inside that rope – my whole life held inside. It is the only space that promised it could hold me, take my imagination and offer it a place to exist, show me every corner of the globe, teach me that the world is as big as my life is small, and take that teenager and make him someone else.

I feel a sudden and profound sense of gratitude. I would happily bowl forever. It could be to all the tens of thousands yesterday that spilt across the playing field at Lord's, or to no one here. Just bowling a ball on a cricket pitch – the feeling of the seam leaving the fingers, knowing that it is exactly right as soon as it leaves the hand. The evolution of self, being able to trace my entire life back through one motion and action. The love of it will never leave me. Then I realise, maybe Jimmy and James, the two characters on and off the field that I was trying to reconcile and keep away from each other, were not two different people after all. It was all me – all the messy complexity of what a human is; I just lived it out under the eternal focus of an England cap. We would always talk about leaving that cap in a better place. I hope, looking out on to this empty pitch, that maybe I have left cricket in a better place too. If not the wickets, then at least with the dedication towards it – a love that is too pure, too unconditional, too deep to ever be put out.